Cedar Payroll Integration Design Review

01. Project brief and evidence boundary

This is a fictional internal record from Cedar Workshop Network. It describes Cedar Payroll Integration Design Review in the area of payroll preparation. Every organization, event, participant, and number is invented for software testing. The record combines a project brief, decision notes, operational scenarios, and a handover appendix. It should be read as one bounded source rather than as an independent verification of the organization's performance.

Local workshop administrators emailed different attendance spreadsheets to payroll, leaving analysts to resolve employee codes and overtime categories by hand before preparing a batch.

The main working role is the payroll analyst. The unit of work is a payroll batch; the record follows its creation, review, correction, and eventual disposition. This vocabulary matters because a record can be created successfully while the larger business activity remains incomplete. A review screen, an exported file, a replayed test, and a production result describe different kinds of evidence. Later sections state which kind is actually available.

The source's status is: Proposal; no implementation. The intended audience includes the working team and the next maintainer who needs to understand a decision without reconstructing it from chat. The document records uncertainty alongside implementation detail. The final metrics section is the place to check actual observations; statements of purpose, acceptance criteria, and future plans elsewhere do not establish that those observations happened.

- Design review only; implementation not authorized
- Use synthetic employee identifiers
- Payment execution explicitly excluded
- No external vendor sandbox access yet

02. Existing workflow and the problem in practice

A typical working day begins when the payroll analyst receives an incomplete description of the next payroll batch. The description may be technically readable but still require a decision about identity, timing, or units. The team therefore distinguished syntactic validity from business validity: being able to import a row does not mean that the row should be approved. That distinction prevents a clean-looking screen from hiding an unresolved operational question.

- Step 1: Receive an attendance workbook.

- Step 2: Match employee codes to the approved directory.

- Step 3: Flag ambiguous overtime categories.

- Step 4: Prepare a draft payroll batch.

- Step 5: Obtain analyst review.

- Step 6: Export a vendor-compatible draft file.

The existing problem was not simply a missing database. A payroll batch could be discussed in one place, changed in another, and checked later by someone who did not see the original request. The proposed record of work makes these transitions visible. It also gives the payroll analyst a place to leave a correction rationale instead of passing an unexplained number to the next person.

An illustrative exception is a late correction after review has begun. The first version remains part of the audit trail, while the corrected version requires its own review. The walkthrough is explanatory; it does not assert that a measured incident occurred. When this record describes an actual fictional observation, it uses the explicit incident or measurement sections rather than relying on this illustrative workflow.

03. Scope, exclusions, and acceptance conditions

The scope centers on payroll batches and their review history. The team deliberately avoided assigning the new component ownership of every upstream and downstream system. A useful result at this boundary is a traceable decision with a clear status, an identifiable input version, and enough context for a person to explain why the decision was made. Broader organizational effects require separate measurements.

- Design review only; implementation not authorized

- Use synthetic employee identifiers

- Payment execution explicitly excluded

- No external vendor sandbox access yet

Acceptance conditions were written as checks that an observer could repeat. A reviewer should be able to locate the original payroll batch, inspect a corrected version without losing the first one, and distinguish a pending state from a completed state. A rejected operation should explain what information is missing. These are proposed or scoped conditions; their presence in the plan does not mean that every one passed in deployment.

The following omissions remain intentional or unresolved: A delivery date has not been committed. The vendor format remains a draft interpretation. There is no observed end-user performance data. A future team can investigate them, but should not fill the gaps with estimates presented as facts. The source does not establish the staffing, spending, or delivery schedule of future work. A later implementation should preserve the distinction between a requirement that was discussed and an observation that was actually recorded.

04. Architecture and record ownership

The proposed service uses a small web form, an API, and PostgreSQL mapping tables. A queue would handle workbook validation. The design calls for a private bucket with a short retention period and a vendor-format exporter; no banking integration is included.

Record	Important fields	Rule
Attendance row	Workshop, employee code, date, hours	Raw attendance remains immutable
Employee alias	Local code, central code, review state	Ambiguous aliases require manual review
Pay category	Source label, vendor label, effective date	Mappings are versioned
Draft batch	Period, reviewer, mapping version	Draft is never equivalent to payment approval
Validation finding	Row, field, explanation	Warnings remain visible on export
Export receipt	Draft checksum, generated time, reviewer	Receipt records generation, not bank acceptance

The ownership boundary is more important than the technology label. The component that accepts a payroll batch owns the validation and status history for that record; it does not automatically become the source of truth for a downstream business result. A maintainer should be able to identify both the original evidence and the decision made from it. Private working material is retained only within the intended test scenario.

A schema migration should preserve old identifiers and the meaning of earlier statuses. Replaying an earlier input against newer code can be useful for diagnosis, but the replay is a new observation with its own conditions. It must not silently rewrite the recorded history of the original attempt. The fictional record therefore keeps input identity, processing state, and human review as separate concepts.

05. Decision log and rejected alternatives

Decision	Recorded rationale
Draft-only boundary	The proposed exporter must never initiate a payment.
Reviewed alias mappings	Employee identity cannot be inferred from similar names.
Versioned category dictionary	Historical payroll drafts need their original mappings.
Synthetic-data prototype	Real employee workbooks are excluded until access review is complete.

The first alternative considered was allowing the payroll analyst to overwrite the latest record without keeping prior values. It was easy to describe, but would have made it difficult to explain which version a colleague had reviewed. The decision notes favor a visible correction path instead. The choice adds a review step, yet preserves the evidence required to diagnose disagreements later.

The second alternative was treating every successful technical operation as business completion. For example, receiving a response or producing an export says that one step finished; it does not prove that all payroll batches reached their intended business destination. The team documented this distinction so that progress updates would not grow into unsupported success claims.

A later team may choose a different implementation if its constraints change. The useful part of this log is the reasoning: The proposed exporter must never initiate a payment. Historical payroll drafts need their original mappings. Those statements explain why the original boundary existed. A replacement should either preserve the same assurance or explicitly record why a different tradeoff is acceptable.

06. Working chronology and review notes

These fictional working dates organize the team's discussion of payroll preparation. They are not deployment receipts. Several activities can occur while a project is still proposed or limited to a controlled environment. Read a date next to its evidence classification rather than assuming that chronological progress implies a launch.

Date	Working note	Evidence classification
2026-03-03	Working session examined: receive an attendance workbook. The note records the question and its required evidence; it does not certify a live release.	Design or review note
2026-03-06	Working session examined: match employee codes to the approved directory. The note records the question and its required evidence; it does not certify a live release.	Design or review note
2026-03-09	Working session examined: flag ambiguous overtime categories. The note records the question and its required evidence; it does not certify a live release.	Design or review note
2026-03-12	Working session examined: prepare a draft payroll batch. The note records the question and its required evidence; it does not certify a live release.	Design or review note
2026-03-15	Working session examined: obtain analyst review. The note records the question and its required evidence; it does not certify a live release.	Design or review note
2026-03-18	Working session examined: export a vendor-compatible draft file. The note records the question and its required evidence; it does not certify a live release.	Design or review note

The review format asked three questions at each transition: what input was available, what decision was made, and what remained unknown? For payroll batches, that prevented missing source material from being concealed by a status update. A note saying that the team examined a scenario only establishes the examination; an observed test result needs an explicit environment and expected behavior.

Meeting notes were kept short enough for the payroll analyst to revisit. Where two notes disagree, the disagreement remains part of the source. A later summary must not select the more optimistic statement merely because it appears later in the file. Closure depends on the evidence and its scope, not on the position of a paragraph.

07. Detailed walkthrough of one unit of work

Scenario 1: Receive an attendance workbook

In this illustrative scenario, the payroll analyst works with the attendance row record while handling a payroll batch. The visible information includes workshop, employee code, date, hours. The governing rule is: Raw attendance remains immutable. If required evidence is absent, the person leaves the operation pending and records the missing condition. This scenario describes intended handling, not a separately measured success rate.

Scenario 2: Match employee codes to the approved directory

In this illustrative scenario, the payroll analyst works with the employee alias record while handling a payroll batch. The visible information includes local code, central code, review state. The governing rule is: Ambiguous aliases require manual review. If required evidence is absent, the person leaves the operation pending and records the missing condition. This scenario describes intended handling, not a separately measured success rate.

Scenario 3: Flag ambiguous overtime categories

In this illustrative scenario, the payroll analyst works with the pay category record while handling a payroll batch. The visible information includes source label, vendor label, effective date. The governing rule is: Mappings are versioned. If required evidence is absent, the person leaves the operation pending and records the missing condition. This scenario describes intended handling, not a separately measured success rate.

Scenario 4: Prepare a draft payroll batch

In this illustrative scenario, the payroll analyst works with the draft batch record while handling a payroll batch. The visible information includes period, reviewer, mapping version. The governing rule is: Draft is never equivalent to payment approval. If required evidence is absent, the person leaves the operation pending and records the missing condition. This scenario describes intended handling, not a separately measured success rate.

Scenario 5: Obtain analyst review

In this illustrative scenario, the payroll analyst works with the validation finding record while handling a payroll batch. The visible information includes row, field, explanation. The governing rule is: Warnings remain visible on export. If required evidence is absent, the person leaves the operation pending and records the missing condition. This scenario describes intended handling, not a separately measured success rate.

Scenario 6: Export a vendor-compatible draft file

In this illustrative scenario, the payroll analyst works with the export receipt record while handling a payroll batch. The visible information includes draft checksum, generated time, reviewer. The governing rule is: Receipt records generation, not bank acceptance. If required evidence is absent, the person leaves the operation pending and records the missing condition. This scenario describes intended handling, not a separately measured success rate.

08. Incident, exception, and recovery record

During a design rehearsal, two synthetic workers shared the same display name. A sketch that matched by name would have joined them incorrectly. The reviewers rejected that design and required stable employee identifiers with an exception list. This was a rehearsal finding, not a production incident or evidence of a deployed fix.

The immediate response separates the current operational question from a permanent fix. The payroll analyst needs to know which payroll batches are affected, which original inputs remain available, and whether continuing would make reconciliation harder. A workaround can restore a narrow workflow while leaving the underlying design question open. That limited restoration should not be reported as proof that the whole component is reliable.

The follow-up record should name the scenario, identify its input version, and state the boundary of any retest. An entry that passes once is a useful observation but does not certify every source format, every operating condition, or every future change. Where this fictional archive has no such result, its absence remains visible rather than being filled by a generalized claim.

09. Observed results, targets, and uncertainty

No implementation, deployment, payroll run, time-saving measurement, payment validation, or user acceptance result is recorded. The proposal targets reducing preparation effort by 40 percent, but that number is a planning hypothesis and has not been measured.

Measure	Starting point or scope	Recorded value	Interpretation limit
Preparation effort	Baseline not collected	Target: 40 percent lower	Planning hypothesis only
Payroll accuracy	Not measured	Not measured	No real payroll was processed
Vendor acceptance	Unavailable	Unavailable	Sandbox access still pending

Interpretation must preserve the environment and denominator attached to a result. A count of payroll batches in a rehearsal cannot be presented as the number completed in production. A time comparison does not establish a separate quality improvement. If an earlier section describes a goal, that goal remains a goal until this section contains a compatible observation with clear scope.

The unresolved items are: A delivery date has not been committed. The vendor format remains a draft interpretation. There is no observed end-user performance data. None of these gaps is resolved by the amount of technical detail in the architecture section. A reader can understand a design well while still being unable to establish its operational outcome. If a summary needs to be shorter, keep the uncertainty rather than removing it to make the project sound complete.

10. Documented lessons and reusable boundaries

- The design review explicitly recorded that display names are unsafe identity keys.

- Reviewers documented the need to distinguish draft generation from payment approval.

- The review notes caution that proposed efficiency targets are not achieved outcomes.

The reusable part is the relationship between a payroll batch, its original evidence, and the review decision. Copying an implementation without that relationship could reproduce the interface while losing the reason that the team could trust a particular status. A future maintainer should ask whether the same identity rules, review authority, and correction history still apply in the new setting.

Reuse also needs a boundary statement. Employee identity cannot be inferred from similar names. That rationale is tied to this project's constraints; it is not a universal rule that replaces investigation. Before adapting the design, compare the new inputs, downstream authority, failure recovery requirements, and evidence needed to claim completion. Differences should be recorded as open decisions rather than hidden inside a copied configuration.

The lessons listed here were explicitly recorded in this fictional source. They are not claims that every recommendation was implemented successfully. In particular, a lesson drawn from a rehearsal or rollback can be valuable even if the project has no positive production outcome. Keep the lesson's origin visible when summarizing it for another team.

11. Handover, access, and operational questions

A person taking over payroll preparation work should first locate the current status of each payroll batch and the original material supporting that status. The handover should distinguish ordinary operation, pending review, and an exception that needs a named decision. Access to a review screen does not grant authority to change a downstream system or certify the final business result.

- Find the original attendance row input before changing a derived field.

- Check the pay category identity and the effective version used by the review.

- Ask the payroll analyst to explain the normal correction path.

- Record the evidence scope when handing an issue to another person.

- Preserve a pending state when the required approval or source is absent.

- Treat environment access and data retention as separate questions from project success.

The archive intentionally does not include credentials, personal production records, or an executable deployment procedure. Environment names in this report identify fictional evidence contexts. They should not be converted into real infrastructure settings. A reader testing a document-processing application can use the text to check whether uncertainty survives summarization without trying to operate the fictional service.

Open handover questions remain concrete: who can authorize a correction, which record version is being reviewed, and what event proves that the next boundary accepted it? A delivery date has not been committed. The vendor format remains a draft interpretation. Those missing answers matter more than a confident closing paragraph. They remain explicit so another reader can decide what evidence to collect next.

12. Evidence index and final source notes

Source marker	What this report actually contains
02-BRIEF	Local workshop administrators emailed different attendance spreadsheets to payroll, leaving analysts to resolve employee codes and overtime categories by hand before preparing a batch.
02-ARCH	The proposed service uses a small web form, an API, and PostgreSQL mapping tables. A queue would handle workbook validation. The design calls for a private bucket with a short retention period and a vendor-format exporter; no banking integration is included.
02-INCIDENT	During a design rehearsal, two synthetic workers shared the same display name. A sketch that matched by name would have joined them incorrectly. The reviewers rejected that design and required stable employee identifiers with an exception list. This was a rehearsal finding, not a production incident or evidence of a deployed fix.
02-RESULT	No implementation, deployment, payroll run, time-saving measurement, payment validation, or user acceptance result is recorded. The proposal targets reducing preparation effort by 40 percent, but that number is a planning hypothesis and has not been measured.
02-GAPS	A delivery date has not been committed. The vendor format remains a draft interpretation. There is no observed end-user performance data.

This index helps a reviewer locate the source of a statement; it is not an additional outcome. The brief describes the problem, the architecture describes component responsibilities, and the incident record describes an exception with its evidence boundary. The results entry is the only consolidated statement of the fictional observations. All quotations should refer to the words actually present in this version of the report.

A future amendment should keep the old record available and say which claim it corrects. For Cedar Workshop Network, that means a new note cannot silently replace the scope of the payroll batches already described here. If later evidence resolves an unknown, the new evidence needs its own date and source. No such later amendment is included in this file.

End of the fictional source record. Current status: Proposal; no implementation. The report ends with the same boundary it began with: a technical description is useful evidence about the design, while an operational result must be grounded in an explicit observation. Any stronger conclusion requires additional source material.